

Reading

A rabbi, a UU minister, and a Wiccan priestess decide to go on a fishing trip together. They go down to their local lake, rent a boat, and go out on to the lake for a day of fishing. As the afternoon approached, the trio became hungry - and realized that they had left their lunches on the shore of the lake. The minister got out of the boat, walked across the lake, got his lunch, walked back, and sat down ... beginning to eat his lunch. "You should have gotten all of our lunches!", scolds the priestess. She then gets up, walks across the lake, picks up her lunch as well as the Rabbi's, walks back across the lake, and sits down ... handing the rabbi his afternoon meal. The rabbi at this point is almost out of his mind, his eyes wide with shock. Finally, he manages to sputter.. "Wha.. what... how did you...?" The minister grins at the priestess, nudges her, and asks "Do you think we should tell him about the rocks?" The priestess looks at the minister, raises an eyebrow, and replies "... what rocks?"

How many UUs does it take to screw in a light bulb?
Twenty. Seven to form a committee to discuss the ecological implications of compact fluorescent vs. incandescent bulbs, six to form a committee to discuss labor practices, six on the aesthetics committee to discuss the exact tint and wattage, and one who goes ahead and does it without consulting anyone else.

Responsive Reading

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

The name of your church is longer than your arm.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You think socks are too formal for a Summer service.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You know at least 5 ways to say "Happy holidays!"

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You find yourself rewriting a church survey, rather than taking it.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You take your day planner to church instead of the Bible.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You have ever been in an argument over whether or not breast milk is vegan.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You get mail from committees you didn't know you were on.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You sent more money to the Sierra Club last year was more than you spent on your mother at Christmas.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You think the Holy Trinity is "reduce, reuse and recycle."

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You have trouble singing hymns because you're always reading ahead to see if you agree with the words.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You study the "ten suggestions" instead of the "Ten Commandments."

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You think a Holy day of Obligation is your turn to do coffee.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You know at least two people who are upset that trees had to die for your church to be built.

You may be a Unitarian Universalist if:

You refer to construction paper as "paper of color."

How Many UU's Does It Take To Screw In a Light Bulb?

How many Unitarian Universalists does it take to change a light bulb? We choose not to make a statement either in favor of or against the need for a light bulb. However, if in your own journey, you have found that light bulbs work for you, that is wonderful. You are invited to write a poem or compose a modern dance about your personal relationship with your light bulb. Present it next month at our annual Light Bulb Sunday Service, in which we will explore a number of light bulb traditions, including incandescent, fluorescent, 3-way, long-life, LED and tinted, all of which are equally valid paths to luminescence.

As UU's we do have a reputation. We're the odd church. We certainly aren't a cult. We don't have one identified charismatic leader guiding us down a promised path. We don't have a creed that defines us. We can't even figure out if we are a church, a fellowship or a society. It's no wonder that we are seen as the religious free thinkers, kind of "out there." We are so hard to pin down it's like nailing jello to a tree.

We have a unique approach to religion. *During coffee hour one Sunday a church member was heard to say "Unitarian Universalists prefer buffet to catered." "What's wrong with catered food?" interrupted another UU, catching only the last part of the conversation. The first explained, "I was referring to theology."*

We do not want our beliefs handed down to us on a platter. Being told what to believe, how to understand or make meaning of our world does not sit well for us. Maybe we're rebellious and have authority issues. Maybe we have intellects can not be confined. Perhaps we felt abused or wounded by a former religious group. Or we might like having an identity that sets us apart as a little bit different. Chances are that each person who claims to be a UU does so for a number of reasons.

The interesting thing is, we are still religious. As I've often said, Unitarian Universalism is not a debate club, a social action organization, a society where the misfits fit in or an educational program. Unitarian Universalism is a religion. In every sense of the word. We just go about it differently.

A UU minister sees a child out in front of a house in the neighborhood she drives through on her way to church, with a sign "Adorable kittens -- FREE." The next day, the minister notices the child out in front of a neighborhood church with a sign saying: "Adorable Methodist Kittens -- FREE." A couple of days later, the kid is posted in front of the synagogue with a sign: "Adorable Jewish Kittens -- Free." So the Minister isn't surprised when, the next Sunday the child is in front of the church she serves with a sign promising "Adorable Unitarian Universalist kittens." "Now really," she tells the child, "they are adorable kittens, but I have a problem with your advertising. I've seen your kittens change their religion every day for a week. Why do you think I'll believe that these are UU kittens now, all of a sudden?" "Well," said the child, "Now they have their eyes open."

Ok. We're different. And one of the reasons we are different is that as a religious organization we "covenant to affirm and promote: ...Acceptance of one another and encouragement to spiritual growth in our congregations and a free and responsible search for truth and meaning.

We are free to work out our own theology. But we don't do this alone. It may be personal theology, but we have an obligation to encourage spiritual growth in our congregations. And our freedom is tied to our responsibility.

This working out of individual beliefs is done within a group. And we do love to talk. The dialoging, asking, challenging and seeking is for many UU's more important than the finding. UU's are people of the question.

*What do the Ku Klux Klan do when they find out a Unitarian Universalist has moved into their neighborhood?
They burn a burn question mark on the front lawn.*

A UU dies and finds himself walking along a road. He comes to a fork in the road. There is a sign that reads, "This Way to Heaven," but the UU goes the other way, where the sign reads, "This Way to a Discussion About Heaven."

How many UU's does it take to change a light bulb?

Well, they've got a discussion group going, and a committee's working on it, and they've written a questionnaire and tallied all the responses, but they can't come to an agreement on the exact number.

A Unitarian Universalist died, and to her surprise discovered that there was indeed an afterlife. The angel in charge of these things told her, "Because you were an unbeliever and a doubter and a skeptic, you will be sent to Hell for all eternity -- which, in your case, consists of a place where no one will disagree with you ever again!"

As Unitarian Universalists, we so prize the exchange of ideas that we even have a time of discussion after the sermon. Think about this for a minute. How radical is it to have time for dialog during the worship service? Worship has been described as focusing on that which is worth-full. Here lies our values.

So we are free to form our own theology and to do so with the support of a religious community. (Again, how radical is that!)

And we are also charged to be responsible in our search for truth and meaning. What does this actually mean? What does it look like? First let me state that we would do well to check our understanding of "responsible." It does not limit us to the idea of "duty." Responsibility is also "the ability to respond."

Some of this is a no-brainer. If we affirm and promote the inherent worth and dignity of every person, we treat each other with care. Certainly basic manners, kindness and good listening skills are foundational. We need also to remember that when we are having conversations about what we believe, why we believe it, how it feels and how we are trying to live it out, we are dealing with the very core of each person. This is Holy Ground.

It is holy, sacred work. The dialog, discussions and debates are for us a religious experience. I don't say this in jest. Our goal is to nurture the spiritual growth of each other and of the community as a whole. We are not trying to win. We do not get notches on our Bibles, or day planners, for every person we convert to our way of thinking. We do not determine the validity of our personal beliefs by how many people we can convince. We are not on commission.

The whole point of our talking is spiritual growth. The gift of a religious community that supports our free and responsible search for truth and meaning is that we are held accountable for what we chose to believe. As individual UU's, our personal theologies are our choice. Remember, truth with a capital "T" is not handed down to us and we are not judged on how well we live up to this pre-packaged truth. Individually, we decide what we will believe.

Does this mean you can believe anything you want? Not if you are going to be a UU. It is the responsibility of our religious community to ask questions, probe, challenge, push. We offer each other reality checks. Searching for truth and meaning is serious stuff, and we need others who will hold us accountable. We are responsible to our community to have theologies that have integrity. This requires learning, studying, digging, examining. It requires paying attention to the heart and the emotions and the gut. If our personal truths can not stand up to honest questions and challenges, then we are on pretty shaky ground.

By joining a UU congregation, we are agreeing to be part of a deep conversation. We have two jobs. One is to continually work out our own theology so it has integrity and congruity. We do this with the support and challenges of our community. Our second job is to continually support and challenge others in our congregation for their spiritual growth. This is to be done with great care, respect and kindness. It does not mean we are not passionate. I hope we are. But we don't win by being "right." We win by growing and helping each other grow, along very different paths. Everyone has a voice, and the right to respect.

Again, How many UU's does it take to change a light bulb?

Ten, of whom at least 5 must be women, one youth, one elderly, two gay or lesbian, one Christian, one Humanist, one Pagan, one disabled, one church board member, and one to make the coffee.

In our congregations, it is important to hear from everyone, or at least make lots of room so that all can speak. Sometimes, oftentimes, we will hear things that are not comfortable. And this is good. We can use it to ask ourselves what it is about what we are hearing that troubles us. We can welcome the thoughts we don't like and use them to test and define our own faith. But in our tolerance I offer two cautions.

Tolerance does not mean that we accept everything. If we have no limits, we also have no definition. One minister was accused of being intolerant when he told the neo-Nazis that they could not come to speak to the congregation. Folks thought it made their church seem unwelcoming. Tolerance should have limits. It comes from a place of strength, not spinelessness. We do not have to welcome everything. All opinions are not equal.

Additionally, being a tolerant church does not mean we accept all behavior or all forms of discourse. People are encouraged to share their views. However, coercing, shoving one's belief down another's throat, or proselytizing are not acceptable. Part of our responsible search for truth and meaning includes holding members of the congregation accountable for how they voice their beliefs and questions, and for how they treat others. Some humility is called for. If you think that you own the truth, this is not the place for you. You must understand that spiritual maturity calls for the ability to hold in tension what we believe and the great mystery.

Each religion has its own Holy Books: Judaism has the Torah. Christianity has the Bible. Islam has the Koran. And Unitarian Universalism has Robert's Rules of Order.

We are not trying to be all things to all people. We don't even say that as UU's we will accept everybody. We will not give you the answers. However, we will join you in the questions. For all the joking, our discussions should be a religious experience. We meet each other on Holy Ground.

It is show-and-tell day at school, and all the children are requested to bring in an item which illustrates their religious beliefs. David stands up and says "This is a star of David and I am a Jew". Dorothy stands up and says "This is a crucifix and I am a Catholic". Jimmy stands up and says "This is a coffeepot and I am a Unitarian Universalist."

So, just what is a UU? And how many UU's does it take to screw in a light bulb? It's only fair to let others know what we are like and what we expect.

- o We are friendly. If you are not friendly, out you go!
- o We are genuine people. Even our phonies are real phonies.
- o We are always sincere even if we have to fake it.
- o We aren't sure how ambivalent we should be.
- o We believe in tolerance and cannot stand intolerant people.
- o We are optimists. Anyone who doesn't look on the bright side depresses us.
- o We are more non-competitive than other groups.
- o We believe in equality; everyone is as good as the next person and a whole lot better.
- o Every Unitarian Universalist is a feminist, so he has to watch his language.
- o The organization is run democratically because the president insists on it.
- o We have our critics, but they are paranoid.
- o We are prompt about being late to meetings.
- o Dogmatism is absolutely forbidden.
- o Freedom of belief is rigidly enforced.

And into this wonderful place we joyfully welcome all those who would join us in the free and responsible search for truth and meaning.

Amen and Amen.